On the National Highway, the scene was no better. The agitators had not only blocked the highway but also vandalized vehicles on the road and buildings and dhabas alongside. A large number of civilians caught up in the violence had to seek refuge in the better-known eateries like Haveli and Sukhdev, though they too were not totally spared. The Army columns had the sensitive task of not only maintaining the peace but also evacuating our distressed countrymen and women. Some senior Army officers were also caught up in the blockade and while extracting them was our priority, they were also our eyes and ears and gave us valuable intelligence on how to proceed. By and by, through the great maturity shown by the officers heading these columns, we were able to pacify the mob. All the stranded persons were taken to safety. The agitators were persuaded to allow at least one carriageway to be opened so that all the stranded vehicles could be moved out. They were also convinced to lift the *rail-roko*, the blockage of the railway tracks that was causing inconvenience to so many thousands of people, by appealing to their conscience.

The government appointed a committee headed by former Director General of Police Prakash Singh to, 'find commissions and omissions on the part of police and administrative officials'. He was scathing in his report and questioned the functioning of the police department as well as the civil administration, who chose to ignore intelligence inputs and tried to play down the possibility of any agitation. In a damning indictment about the role of the state police, the report observed, 'The state could not possibly complain of a shortage of manpower. What was lacking was the will to act.' He wrote in his report, 'You would have seen cops running away, but wouldn't have ever seen Army running away.' The papers also reported that '5000 [Army personnel] could do what 50,000 [police] could not.'[5]

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